NINJAS STEM FOUNDATION

Youth Protection & Safety Policy

POLICY ID NSF-YS-01 | STATUS Proposed for Board approval | EFFECTIVE DATE _____

1. Purpose

The safety, dignity, and wellbeing of students are fundamental to the educational mission of Ninjas STEM Foundation.

This Policy establishes standards for preventing abuse and misconduct, maintaining appropriate adult supervision, operating safe robotics activities, protecting students during events, and responding to safety concerns.

Student safety takes precedence over competition results, deadlines, fundraising, or organizational reputation.

2. Applicability and Responsibility

This Policy applies to NSF directors, officers, committee members, coaches, mentors, volunteers, and other adults participating in Foundation activities involving minors.

Students and parents shall receive age-appropriate information about relevant safety expectations.

For activities governed by an external competition, school, venue, or program, NSF shall also follow applicable external requirements. Where standards differ, NSF shall use the more protective applicable requirement.

The Board shall appoint a responsible adult or program lead to administer safeguarding procedures. A separate, accessible reporting route shall be available when that person is involved in a concern.

3. Adult Eligibility, Screening, and Training

Adults undertaking ongoing coaching, supervision, or other active roles involving minors must complete the screening, clearance, policy acknowledgment, and training required for the particular activity before beginning those duties.

Screening shall comply with applicable law and the relevant competition organization's requirements. A background check obtained through another organization shall not automatically substitute for required program-specific clearance.

An individual who has not completed required clearance shall not serve in a role requiring it.

Screening information shall be maintained confidentially and accessed only by authorized persons with an appropriate purpose.

4. Adult Supervision and Observable Interactions

Student activities shall be conducted in locations permitting appropriate adult observation and interruption.

NSF shall normally arrange at least two responsible adults for activities involving minors whenever practical and shall comply with any higher applicable event or competition requirement.

For ordinary VEX team practices, an eligible cleared adult may supervise in circumstances permitted by the applicable VEX youth-protection rules, provided the setting remains open and observable and parents know the location, schedule, and supervising adult.

A non-related adult shall not be alone with a single student in a private or unobservable setting.

If only one student remains with one non-related adult, the organized activity shall end and the student shall be supervised in an observable location until released to an authorized parent or guardian.

A genuine emergency may require temporary protective measures. Such circumstances shall be documented promptly.

5. Private-Home Practices and Meetings

For activities held at a private residence:

- Parents shall receive the location, schedule, supervising-adult information, and pickup arrangements.
- The instructional area shall remain appropriate for observable supervision.
- Students shall not be left unsupervised in private areas of the residence.
- Attendance and authorized pickup information shall be maintained.
- Adults shall have a procedure for late pickup, illness, injury, or early departure.

Use of a family home does not reduce the applicable safeguarding requirements.

6. Adult–Student Boundaries and Communications

Adults shall maintain professional and age-appropriate boundaries.

Program-related electronic communication with a minor shall occur through an approved group channel accessible to another authorized adult or parent, or shall include another authorized adult or the student's parent or guardian.

Private, secret, or unrelated personal communication between an adult and a minor is prohibited.

Adults shall not engage in grooming, inappropriate physical contact, sexual misconduct, intimidation, humiliation, bullying, discriminatory harassment, or exploitation.

Students shall not be instructed to conceal program communications or activities from their parents or guardians.

7. Robotics Equipment and Workshop Safety

Students shall receive age-appropriate safety instruction before using tools, electrical equipment, batteries, mechanical assemblies, or fabrication equipment.

Appropriate personal protective equipment shall be used when required.

Power tools, cutting equipment, machinery, and other higher-risk operations require designated adult authorization and supervision.

Students shall not operate tools for which they have not received appropriate training.

Damaged batteries, exposed electrical connections, moving mechanisms, and other hazards shall be addressed promptly.

The responsible coach or supervisor may stop any unsafe activity immediately.

8. Transportation, Competitions, and Off-Site Activities

Transportation arrangements shall be communicated and authorized before an activity.

An adult shall not transport a non-related minor in a personal vehicle without prior written parent or guardian permission, except where a genuine emergency necessitates immediate protective action.

Competition travel and overnight activities shall comply with applicable program safeguards, adult supervision, parental authorizations, venue rules, and accommodation requirements.

Separate event plans shall identify the responsible adults, emergency contacts, student supervision arrangements, and pickup or transportation responsibilities.

9. Health, Accessibility, and Emergency Response

NSF shall maintain appropriate emergency contact information and seek relevant information needed to make safe participation arrangements.

Medical and disability-related information shall be handled confidentially.

Reasonable accommodations and support arrangements shall be considered individually, in consultation with the parent or guardian and consistent with applicable law.

Adults shall not independently provide intimate personal care or administer medication outside an appropriately authorized arrangement.

In an emergency, the responsible adult shall secure immediate assistance, contact emergency services when needed, and notify the parent or guardian as soon as appropriate.

Incidents and material near misses shall be documented and reviewed.

10. Reporting Abuse, Neglect, and Safety Concerns

Any person having reasonable cause to believe that a child has been abused or neglected shall comply with Texas Family Code §261.101 and other applicable reporting law.

A report must be made immediately when required under the general Texas reporting rule. Covered professionals are subject to the applicable 24-hour reporting requirement and may not delegate their reporting responsibility.

No person shall be required to obtain permission from NSF, complete an internal investigation, or first notify the Board before making a legally required report.

Immediate danger shall be reported to emergency services or law enforcement.

Suspected abuse or neglect may be reported through the appropriate Texas child-protection authorities.

Where an incident is connected to an external competition, required reports shall also be made through the competition organization's reporting channels.

Internal NSF notification should occur when lawful and appropriate, but it does not replace an external reporting obligation.

11. Interim Protective Measures

NSF may immediately restrict an individual's access to students when reasonably necessary to address an identifiable safety concern.

Such action is protective and does not itself establish a final finding of wrongdoing.

The responsible decision-maker shall preserve relevant records, document the reason for the restriction, and arrange prompt review by an appropriately authorized and unconflicted person or body.

NSF shall not undertake an internal investigation that interferes with law enforcement or child-protection authorities.

12. Privacy, Media, and Recordkeeping

Student photographs, recordings, personal information, screening records, and incident reports shall be handled under the Foundation's privacy, media-consent, and records-management policies.

Public media use requires the permissions specified in the separate Photo & Video Consent Policy.

Safety records shall be protected from unnecessary access and preserved as required by law, applicable program rules, and document-retention obligations.

13. Non-Retaliation and Review

Retaliation against any person who raises a safety concern or makes a lawful good-faith report is prohibited.

Students shall not be penalized for reporting discomfort, seeking assistance, or declining an unsafe activity.

The Board shall review this Policy at least annually and following material changes in law, competition requirements, or NSF operations.